ACT / ENGLISH / FREE GUIDE

ACT English Grammar Cheat Sheet

Make confident edits with a clear checklist for grammar, clarity, and purpose.

By TestPrepUnraveled • Updated September 12, 2026 • 5 min read

Read beyond the underlined words

An edit must fit the whole sentence and often the surrounding paragraph. Read enough context to identify the subject, verb, timeline, and purpose. An answer can be grammatically correct but logically wrong in the passage.

Check sentence boundaries first

Locate independent and dependent clauses before judging punctuation. A period and a semicolon can separate two complete thoughts. A colon should follow a complete clause. Avoid both fragments and comma splices.

Choose clear, precise wording

When choices communicate the same meaning, unnecessary repetition weakens the sentence. Concision is useful only when it preserves meaning and grammar. Do not pick the shortest answer if it removes an essential relationship.

Match the writer’s purpose

For adding, deleting, or moving a sentence, use the question’s stated goal. Ask whether the proposed text supports the paragraph’s focus. For transitions, identify addition, contrast, cause, or example before choosing a word.

YOUR DESK-SIDE REFERENCE

Quick reference

Issue	What to check	Example
Redundancy	Does a phrase repeat an idea?	Use “returned,” not “returned back.”
Agreement	What is the actual subject?	Each of the players is ready.
Transition	How do the ideas relate?	However signals a contrast.
Modifier	Who performs the action?	Carrying a bag, Ava entered.
Relevance	Does the detail support the purpose?	Keep details that advance the paragraph.

Original worked example

Revise: “The club collaborated together to plan the event.”

“The club collaborated to plan the event.” Collaborated already expresses working together, so together repeats the meaning.

A tip worth keeping

For a transition question, describe the relationship in your own words before reading the choices.

Your quick checklist

- Identify the exact task before working.
- Show the reasoning, not just the answer.
- Review the mistake and try a new example.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Try it yourself

These original questions were written for this guide. Try each one before reading the answer key.

1. Choose: “Neither of the routes (seems / seem) shorter.”

2. “The forecast predicted rain. ___, the afternoon remained sunny.” Choose “Similarly” or “However.”

3. A paragraph explains how a mural was painted. Should it add an unrelated detail about the artist’s favorite meal?

Answers & explanations

1. Seems. Neither is singular in this sentence.

2. However. The second sentence contrasts with the expectation in the first.

3. Usually no. The detail does not explain the painting process or support that paragraph’s focus.

Keep your prep current

Check your test provider for current rules and format details. These are independent sample guides and contain no official test questions.

Official ACT format updates

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